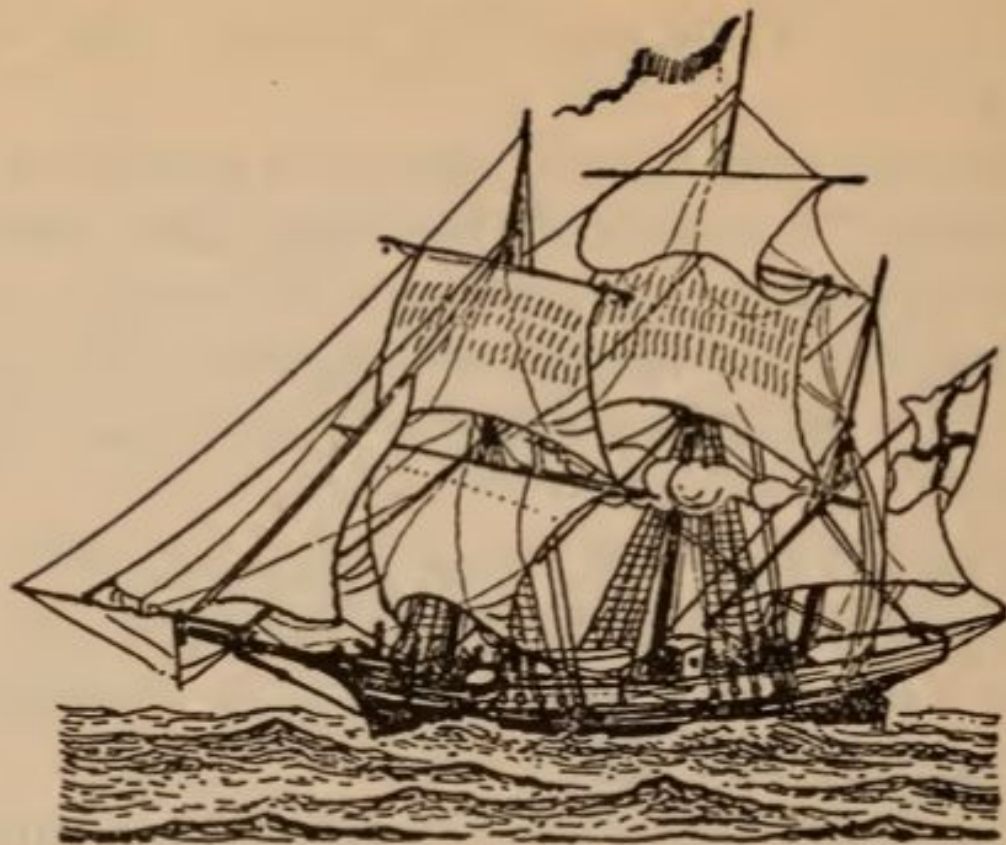


Carry On, Mr. Bowditch

Chapter 17



CHAPTER 17



LUNARS AND MOONLIGHT

"I want to hear all about everything, Nat," Elizabeth said.

David Farrel smiled. "We both do!"

Nat thanked them. He told Elizabeth he'd try to see her soon. When I get over feeling like a fool! he told himself. Just now, he said, he must go to the Custom House with Captain Prince.

"Perhaps this evening?" Elizabeth asked.

It might be a week or two before he could see her, he said. He'd be awfully busy, taking care of the cargo.

For a moment Elizabeth's eyes studied him gravely, then she smiled, and said it was fine he was home. She left the wharf — with David Farrel.

After Captain Prince and Nat reported to the Custom House, they went to Mr. Derby's office.

Mr. Derby questioned them briefly, and nodded. His mind did not seem to be on the success of the *Astrea*. He

told them news of the war threat. The trouble with France dragged on.

"It'll never be settled until this country wakes up and builds a navy!" Prince said.

Mr. Derby nodded. "President Washington knows we need a navy." He unfolded a newspaper. "Here's what he said in his Eighth Annual Message to Congress, last December." He read some passages he had marked:

"To an active external Commerce, the protection of a Naval force is indispensable . . .

. . . it is in our experience that the most sincere Neutrality is not a sufficient guard against the depredations of Nations at War. To secure respect to a Neutral Flag,

requires a Naval force, organized, and ready to vindicate it from insult or aggression. This may even prevent the necessity of going to War."

Prince said, "And he's right! But when will he convince Congress?"

"They're finally convinced," Mr. Derby said. "They've authorized the building of six frigates."

"Humph!" Prince said, "*six* frigates!"

Mr. Derby nodded. "I know, it is not enough. I'm urging the government to let private citizens build warships, too. Salem will build a frigate, the minute we have permission."

Nat thought of what men said of Mr. Derby — that he could “see around corners.” Did he see war coming now, in spite of all our efforts to stay at peace?

Mr. Derby’s secretary interrupted to say that Mr. Blunt, the publisher from Newbury, wanted to see them.

A moment later an impatient young man entered the office, nodded briefly to Mr. Derby and Captain Prince, and glared at Nat.

“I was talking to Mr. Collins,” he said. “He tells me you think you found an error in Moore’s *Navigation!*”

“I did.”

"In which table?" Nat told him. Mr. Blunt gave a short laugh and relaxed. "Do you know who compiled that table? Nevil Maskelyne! The royal astronomer of England! You'd be as apt to find a mistake in — well — in Newton's *Principia*!"

"*Principia*?" Nat said. "I did find an error in it. Let's see if I can quote the spot . . . Well, roughly translated, it went something like this . . ." And he quoted the passage and pointed out the error.

Mr. Blunt's jaw fell. "Well, I'll be . . . Where did you go to college? London? Paris? You didn't get that kind of education here! Where did you go?"

"I didn't."

Mr. Blunt opened his mouth twice before any sound came. Finally he said, "Er — could you point out the error in Maskelyne's table?"

"Which one?" Nat asked. "There were several."

Mr. Blunt's round face swelled and turned red. At last he swallowed hard and muttered, "All of them."

Captain Prince said, "And you might ask him about his new way of working lunars, Mr. Blunt."

"A new way of working lunars!"

Nat explained it briefly.

Mr. Blunt's jaw dropped again. "But — but — that's tremendous! I'd like to include it in the new edition of

Moore that I'm bringing out. And — and — if you could just cast your eye over some of the tables in the book . . .”

“You don't ‘cast your eye’ over navigation tables!” Nat barked. “When I checked that one table of Maske-lyne's, I worked every figure three times, just to be sure I was right!”

“Three times? Every figure? But why in — ”

“Why not?” Nat roared. “Mathematics is nothing if it isn't correct! Men's lives depend on those figures!”

Mr. Blunt swelled up and turned red again, but after a little he said, "Quite so, Mr. Bowditch. I wish we had time for you to check all the tables in Moore. At any rate, I certainly want to include your new method of taking lunars."

Nat promised to see him in two weeks, when they'd taken care of their cargo. Soon he, Captain Prince, and Mr. Derby were deep in figures.

Time and again during the next two weeks Nat thought of Elizabeth. Was he ready to see her now? Ready to feel like a big brother — or father — or something of the sort? He'd give himself a little more time, he decided.

When he was done checking on the cargo, he was glad he had another excuse to put off seeing her. He must talk to Mr. Blunt about Moore's *Navigator*.

"I wish we had time for you to check all the tables," Mr. Blunt repeated. "But a great many of the signatures of the book are already printed." He must have seen Nat's bewilderment. He said, "Perhaps you think of a signature as a man's name. We printers have another

meaning for it. A signature is a single large sheet of paper, on which certain pages of the book are printed. We arrange the pages so that, when the signature is folded and trimmed, the pages are in order."

Nat said he'd be glad to check some of the tables that weren't yet printed. Glad of an excuse to keep busy, he thought.

He worked on the tables, and the thought of Elizabeth stayed somewhere under the figures — most of the time. I'm getting over it, he told himself. But every time there was a knock on his door, his heart jumped. Maybe it was a message from Elizabeth. But it never was.

Dr. Prince came to see him. "I just wanted to remind you, Nat — the Philosophical Library is still open to you — if you want to read the books."

Nat thanked him. "I've been thinking about the library, Dr. Prince. I'd like to join it now — if it's all right with the members."

"More than all right! We'll be honored to have you!" Dr. Prince's eyes twinkled. "I'm sure the books will be pleased. No one else has ever understood them so well as you."

Dr. Holyoke came, wanting to hear all about the lunars, firsthand, and to talk astronomy with Nat. Nat felt a warm glow of pleasure. Dr. Holyoke was more than a beloved physician; he was one of the founders of the American Academy of Arts and Sciences in Boston.

"I correspond with quite a few astronomers," Dr. Holyoke said, "but I don't have much chance to talk to one."

"I'm no astronomer!" Nat protested.



The Captain's Walk

"No? But you figured an easier and more accurate way to check longitude. Astronomers and scientists have been working on that quite a while — for several hundred years."

"The chronometer's the best way," Nat said. "When all ships can afford a chronometer . . ."

"Until they can, they'll bless you and your lunars — even if you aren't an astronomer. Come to think of it — I believe a carpenter invented the chronometer, didn't he?" Dr. Holyoke grinned and was gone.

Alone again, Nat tried to work, but it was no use. He really should call on the Boardmans, he told himself. He should tell Mrs. Boardman about the man he'd met in Manila who'd known her husband.

At the Boardmans', old Minna greeted Nat with a smile. Mrs. Boardman and the girls would be so sorry to miss him, she said. They were in Boston. Hard to tell when they would be back. Mrs. Boardman wrote that they were having a fine time. So many parties. David Farrel was in Boston, too.

Nat went back to his work.

Nat went back to his work.

Autumn came; the trees flamed scarlet and yellow; the harvest moon was gold. A note came for Nat. In Elizabeth's handwriting. His fingers shook when he opened it. A group were going Thursday night to a farm for a party, Elizabeth wrote.

The grownups will visit in Mr. Wiggins' house, but we're going to have a party in the barn. A husking bee. And bob for apples, and everything. I do hope you can come. Especially.

Nat went to sleep smiling. She wanted him — especially!

Thursday morning, he saw David Farrel. David was cheerful, too. "We're awfully glad you can come, Nat. I — well, this is just between us — but I'm hoping to make a very important announcement tonight."

"Are you?" Nat realized how flat his words sounded. He forced himself to smile. "That's fine!"

"Nothing settled yet," David said, "so you won't tell anyone?"

“Not a word,” Nat promised. He went home with a cold lump in his chest where his heart should be. So that was why Elizabeth hoped he could come — especially. He was to be “among the first to know.” “Big brother!” Nat muttered. “It’s a wonder David didn’t ask my permission instead of her mother’s!” Five times that afternoon he decided he wouldn’t go. Five times he changed his mind.

At seven o’clock that evening he was alone in the crowd in Wiggins’ barn. Not that anyone could tell how he felt. He was sure of that. He knew his face kept

smiling, all by itself; he'd given it a good talking-to before he came. He knew his tongue kept making the right answers. But his thoughts were anywhere else — everywhere else. The party at Mary's, when he'd first talked to Elizabeth; the morning after Lizza's funeral, when Elizabeth had brought him the Latin book; most of all, the morning he sailed on the *Astrea*, when Elizabeth told him good-by. When Elizabeth stood on tiptoe . . .

The crowd began husking corn. David called cheerily, "Here, Nat! Sit by us! We've saved you a place!"

Nat's face smiled; his tongue said, "Oh, fine!"

He sat by Elizabeth, husked corn, and smiled at David's constant stream of chatter.

"I haven't found a red ear yet!" David complained. "I should have bribed Mr. Wiggins to save me a dozen." He bent his head and looked into Elizabeth's face. "You know what that means, me proud beauty! Thirteen kisses!"

"A dozen is twelve," Elizabeth said. "Tell him, Nat."

David laughed. "I have a baker somewhere in my ancestors. I always give thirteen kisses for a dozen. One for your right eyebrow, one for your left eyebrow, and —"

Nat didn't realize his hands had stopped husking corn. An ear hit him on the chin. Someone yelled, "Nat! Get to work!"

Smiling again, Nat grabbed an ear of corn, ripped back the husk — the ear was red.

A shout of laughter went up. "Kiss her, Nat! Kiss her!"

Nat's heart sank. What a time to kiss Elizabeth. He'd dreamed of this minute halfway around the world. In his dreams, they would have been alone — maybe looking at the stars. He would have told her the legend of Machico and then — somehow — he'd never figured out just how — he would have worked around to telling her that he loved her.

But now, in the midst of two dozen teasing, laughing people, he must kiss her and make a joke of it. He ordered his face to smile again, and put his arm around her. He couldn't think of anything funny to say, so he

borrowed David's words. "Come here, me proud beauty!"

She turned to him, laughing, and was suddenly grave. "Nat!" she whispered.

Nat found he didn't have to work around to what he wanted to say. He just said it. "I love you, Elizabeth. I've always loved you since you were . . ." And he kissed her.

Another ear of corn hit Nat. Another voice shouted, "Here, Nat!"

Nat saw the ripped-back husk, and the red kernels. He laughed and tossed the ear on the pile of corn. "Keep it! I don't need it!" He pulled Elizabeth to her feet. "Where's your mother?"

Elizabeth's eyes widened. "In . . . in . . . the house."

"Then come on! I have something to say to her!"

Outside the barn, Elizabeth stopped, and leaned against the barn door. "Let's just stand here a minute, Nat, till I — get my breath."

Nat chuckled, leaned his hand against the door, and stood watching her face in the moonlight.

stood watching her face in the moonlight.

"Is — is — the moon that big everywhere, Nat?"

"Nowhere but in Salem," he told her. "Other places, it's just — well — moon-size."

"How — how — big is moon-size?"

He teased her. "You really want to know? Or are you scared of your mother?"

"I'm not a bit scared! I want to know about the moon!"

"Well," Nat drawled, "the closest estimation we have is that the diameter is two thousand, one hundred and sixty miles. Now, shall we go?"

From the doorway, someone said, "People are right. Figures *do* run out his ears, don't they?". It was Polly. The three of them laughed together.

"She's just stalling; I think she's scared of her mother," Nat said.

"Pooh! Aunt Mary won't argue about it," Polly said. "She should have seen this coming for ages!"

Nat blinked. "What!"

"A woman can always tell about things like this."

Nat teased her. "*A woman?*"

Polly tossed her head. "*A girl*, then! But a girl knows more about love before she's a woman than a man ever knows!" She went back in the barn.

Elizabeth said, "Tell me some more about the moon, Nat."

Nat chuckled. "The radiance of the moon is special in Salem. It comes from your face." He stopped, pleased with himself. "That was almost like poetry, wasn't it? I — I — wish I could make pretty speeches."

Elizabeth tucked her hand under his arm. "Pretty speeches! When a man can make pretty speeches, I always wonder how long he's been practicing! Come on, Nat. Let's tell mother!"

Nat. Let's tell mother!

In March, just before Nat's birthday, they were married. The months that followed were the happiest Nat had ever known. The only shadow that ever crossed their days came from news of the sea; a ship long overdue, a ship returning with word of missing men, a ship reported lost in action against the French, and men coming back with grim tales of storms off the Cape or the Horn.

Then Elizabeth's eyes would darken with fear. "Nat,

I hope you never double the Cape again! I — I — couldn't sleep, thinking about it!"

"The Cape's not so bad. You're safer there than lots of places. For instance — take the Mediterranean. There — you'd be running from a French privateer, and probably be hulled by a Barbary pirate." And he told her horrendous tales of what happened to crews that were captured by the Barbary pirates — men put in chains — sold as slaves.

Elizabeth finally agreed that perhaps the Cape wasn't so bad, after all. Nat felt proud of himself, making the Mediterranean sound worse than the Cape.

Captain Prince came to call. The *Astrea* was sailing again in August. "I want you as supercargo, Nat. And — no more second mate's duty for you — no watches to stand."

Nat grinned. "I'd want to be worth my salt between ports."

"You are; *you* and your teaching. I've spent a long time at sea, but I've never had less trouble with a crew. So you'll come? Supercargo — and all your time your own between ports?"

"Now?" Elizabeth protested, "when there's so much trouble with France?"

Prince shrugged it off. "There's nothing to worry about. Do you think Derby would send the *Astrea* now if he thought there was any danger? He knows things are quieting down."

Elizabeth didn't look convinced. "With all those frigates being built? The *Constitution* and the *Constellation* and —"

"That's why things are quieting down," Prince declared. "The best way to stay at peace is to be prepared for war."

Elizabeth finally smiled. "Of course. I'll remember that. And I — I — hope you have a good voyage."

Prince smiled. "You're a proper mariner's wife, Elizabeth. You know an anchor won't hold if the cable's too short. A man always needs another shot in the locker."

Elizabeth's smile was puzzled.

"Another length of cable to stick out when a ship threatens to drag her anchor," Prince said.

"I'll remember that," Elizabeth promised.

"Good!" Captain Prince smiled. "Nothing to worry about. This is just a short trip. To Cadiz — then into the Mediterranean, to Alicante." He waved a gay salute and was gone.

Into the Mediterranean! Elizabeth paled and was silent. Nat couldn't think of anything to say, either — not after all the stories he'd told her about the dangers of the Mediterranean. She said she had just thought of something, and fled up the stairs. Nat started after her, and then turned back, cursing himself for a fool. What could a man tell a woman about the sea — so that she wouldn't worry?

Elizabeth did not come downstairs again until supper-time. She was still pale, but she laughed and talked of everything but the sea. After supper, though, conversation lagged. Nat was glad when someone knocked. It was Lem Harvey, dressed in his best, with his wife and his brother-in-law, Zack Selby.

"The wife just had to see you, Mr. Bowditch, sir."

Amanda Harvey said, "To thank you for what you did for Lem! I — I — can't tell you how much I thank you!

My Lem's signed on the *Betsy* as second mate!"

Zack Selby sneered. "You'd think he was running a whole fleet of ships, single-handed, to hear her take on."

Sour grapes, Nat thought. Zack's still before the mast, and he's ten years older than Lem. He said, "I'm glad for Lem, Amanda, but I didn't do it for him. He did it for himself. He worked and studied harder than any man in the crew."

"That's just it, sir!" Amanda said. "Nobody else ever got him to stick his nose in a book!"

Zack sneered again. "Books! Salem men have come to a pretty pass when they have to sail by books! Time was they could double the Horn with nothing but log, lead, and lookout."

“That’s right,” Nat agreed. “They doubled the Horn. And sometimes they got home again. But what about all the ships that don’t come home? If ‘sailing by book’ makes men a little safer, what’s wrong with it?”

Zack lowered his gaze and shuffled his feet. “Ain’t just my idea,” he muttered. “Plenty men think what I think. Sailing by book is a mighty lubberly business.”

Amanda said, “Oh, *you!* Don’t pay any attention to him, Mr. Bowditch! His nose is out of joint. Lem and me — we’re mighty proud of a book-sailor in the Harvey family!”

When they had gone, Elizabeth smiled. "And I'm mighty proud of a supercargo in the Bowditch family. Nat, darling, forgive me for being such a coward this afternoon. I won't do it again, I promise you."

Two days later, Captain Prince was back — not smiling this time. "You and your teaching!" he roared. "Lem Harvey's shipped as second mate on the *Betsy*!"

Elizabeth's eyes widened. "But, Captain Prince, aren't you proud of him?"

Prince flushed, then growled, "Oh, of course! Just pleased to pieces. But — but — blast it all — he was the best man we had on the guns! We needed him!" And he stamped out.

Elizabeth gasped. "Nat! There is danger! He knows it! Oh, darling . . ." She stopped. "I'm sorry. I'm not going to spoil the rest of our time together."

Nat hugged her. "Ten years from now, we'll be laughing at this, won't we?"

"Of course! No more solemn talk!"

She kept her promise until the August morning the *Astrea* was to sail. Then she stared at Nat with stricken eyes. "Nat, dear . . . Good-by, darling."

Nat teased her gently. "I'm going to teach you French. They say it better: *au revoir*. That's till your return. Good-by always sounds so final."

Elizabeth whitened. "I didn't mean it that way, Nat! I didn't! But — if it were good-by, Nat, remember this. You've made me happier than any other girl ever was in the world!"

A chill tingled Nat's spine. He kissed her. "*Au revoir*."

"Good-by, Nat . . ." Then, quickly, she added. "I'll learn French when you come back!"

Nat smiled, but he felt a cold lump in his chest.